



House in disorder

Parliament is not a gladiatorial arena of victors and vanquished

Just as the monsoon session of Parliament began on July 20, the student protest demanding the resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan, as Union Education Minister, gathered momentum. The BJP had the context and the confidence to turn the session into a theatre of its triumph, powered, most remarkably, by its victory in the West Bengal Assembly election. But the popular reaction to the brutal crackdown on the protesting students by the Delhi Police turned its plans upside down, as rogue policemen were filmed assaulting and attempting to sexually abuse young people. Though no accountability has yet been fixed for the blatant violations of the law by police personnel, the BJP and the Union government have had to face sustained criticism from the Opposition and sections of public opinion. Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Home Minister Amit Shah barely attended the proceedings. Several Bills were passed, with inadequate deliberation. The government passed a Bill which facilitates the operation of a February guideline by the Home Ministry on the mandatory singing of the full version of *Vande Mataram*, the national song, at state functions. The Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Bill, passed amid Opposition protests, overlooks concerns about its potential to undermine federalism and the rights of those on resource-rich land.

The amendment to mining regulations follows the unfortunate pattern of hurried lawmaking and the continuing expansion of the powers of the central government at the cost of States and local communities. The session also legislated stronger measures against malpractices in examinations, in an effort to calm the anger of students. Whether those measures will be adequate to restore trust in the education system, remains to be seen. Mr. Pradhan eventually resigned during the session. Two other legislative attempts, the first, to rush through a new architecture for the delimitation process and the second, to regulate foreign contributions, did not entirely materialise, but both remain alive. It need not have been this way. The government should hold broader and more transparent consultations on both delimitation and the proposed FCRA amendments. The FCRA Amendment Bill will now be examined by a Joint Parliamentary Committee, but the exercise should not be reduced to a mere numbers game. The Centre must convene an all-party meeting, circulate draft legislation, and consult State Chief Ministers on its proposals on delimitation. The Opposition may have succeeded in stalling the government's moves on delimitation and the FCRA, but it should not be triumphant. As the BJP itself discovered, political circumstances can turn rapidly. At any rate, Parliament should not be treated as a gladiatorial arena where one side vanquishes the other. It must remain a forum for constant conversation and the collective pursuit of solutions to the problems confronting the nation.

Internet unbound

India's social media now resemble China's tightly controlled cyberspace

The Union government has summoned Facebook and Instagram parent Meta, and given senior staff from the firm a dressing down. Publicly, the reason is the brief removal, in India, of a video message by Prime Minister Narendra Modi. However, the government is hardly making a secret of its intent to nudge Meta to suppress posts of protests such as the one at Jantar Mantar. A barrage of takedown notices have already erased or suppressed some of the more emblematic forms of the protests. Instagram Reels, where users are shown automatically recommended posts from various creators, have emerged as one of the most influential forms of mass media in the country. Seeking suppression of political speech on such a platform would put India in unenviable company, joining the ranks of Pakistan, where TikTok was banned for some time in 2021 until it agreed to “control immoral/indecent content”. More importantly, it would bring India much closer to the tightly controlled digital ecosystem of China, where nearly all dissent is wiped out in mere minutes. All that possibly stands in the way of India's cyberspace drifting to that status quo is a lack of capacity to check posts in real time, a “problem” that is ripe for a destructive AI-based solution.

Meta is no bastion of resistance in spite of being a central site of the mobilisations over the last few weeks. For months, it has crawled when asked to bend, by needlessly taking down every post referred to it under Section 79(3)(b) of the Information Technology Act, 2000, a censorship route that merely notifies platforms that the reporting agency feels the content referred to is illegal. Despite posts taken down under this section almost never going to court, Meta has uniformly chosen to comply automatically. This has set the stage for the arm-twisting that the government appears to be undertaking. The conditions that enabled widespread censorship in China were fostered over the decades preceding the Internet's growth. In the absence of those conditions, and in the absence of a single-party system with a stated ideological commitment to centralise control, the Internet cannot be tamed. But warping the public's cultural self-perception is damaging for society, and must be stopped. These draconian measures can be used by successive governments if left unchecked. The current dispensation has drawn the wrong lesson from the protests and the accompanying online zeitgeist. Mass mobilisations are the lifeblood of democracy, not an aberration that bears no repetition.

The nation has entered its 80th year of Independence. This is an occasion when all Indians, rising above their differences, will join together in paying homage to their freedom fighters, whose endless exertions and sacrifices delivered the people from the British colonial rule. This is when a subject nation rose to freedom to embark upon its ‘tryst with destiny’ and found its soul in the promised freedom and dignity of a people, long oppressed.

India has since traversed a long distance, navigating a turbulent course of history, managing religious, caste and regional conflicts as also economic disparities. India has suffered wars, terrorism, famines and pandemics. And, today it can justly pride itself in its scientific and technological accomplishments, its defence and nuclear capabilities, a robust economy and a leadership role in the shaping of a new world order.

The erosion of fraternity

But an objective audit of the nation's trajectory as a democracy must contend with grave challenges to the aspiration for an inclusive and benevolent society. Without a partisan apportioning of blame or underplaying national achievements, India must consider whether its politics as practised in the decades gone by has secured fraternity amongst fellow citizens. The heightened disparities and communal discord have resulted in the othering of large sections of its people.

The pervasive arrogance of power at all levels defies the constitutional and moral constraints upon its exercise. Transgression of constitutionally demarcated jurisdictions by the co-equal branches of the Indian state and the strained Centre-State relations are ominous signals for the future of India's federal polity. The pursuit of politics fixated on the acquisition of power at any cost, unconcerned with the means and ends, is a clear affront to the moral injunctions that undergird the founders' vision of a just political order. Electoral outcomes influenced by money, muscle and a pliant bureaucracy suborn the autonomy of voters and interrogate the purity of the country's electoral processes.

A political culture in which opponents are crushed into submission, conscientious dissenters are trolled to unbearable levels of humiliation, and their reputations maligned and families targeted, question the idea of politics as the highest form of public service that, as Thomas Mann famously reminded us, determines the destiny of man in our times. Clearly, substantive democracy is more than majoritarian triumphalism. It is about the vindication of justice, freedom and human dignity perched at the zenith of constitutional fundamentals.

The mixed performance of their roles by constitutional institutions has added to the nation's democratic deficit. The Supreme Court of India's role as custodian of individual freedoms



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Indians must confront the country's democratic failings and reclaim hope

and as sentinel on the *qui vive* has been increasingly scrutinised in recent times. Notwithstanding the richness of its profound pronouncements in Puttaswamy (2017), Romila Thapar (2018), Navtej Johar (2018) and the ‘Bulldozer’ justice case (2024) *et al.*, some of its recent decisions, particularly in bail matters, and delays in its adjudicatory processes have been critiqued as abnegation of the judicial function.

In some instances, it has preferred a “formal or barren legalism” (against which, years ago, Chief Justice of India H.J. Kania had cautioned us), to justify long incarceration of the accused without trial. The Court appears to have failed to enforce its edicts and indifference to media trials that impinge on the fairness of the judicial process has dented its credibility. The functioning of the collegium system in the matter of appointment of judges has contributed to the diminished moral authority of the highest court.

Parliament, as the highest forum of India's representative democracy, has long ceased to be an institution for informed deliberations about the country's future. Floating political loyalties of elected representatives of the people mock its institutional sanctity. The Election Commission of India needs to rescue its battered reputation as the chief superintendent of the country's electoral processes by dispelling widespread doubts about its functioning, even as it may rightfully claim credit for successfully conducting the world's largest electoral exercises over the years. Exceptions apart, the credentials of the Indian media as guardians of public interest are suspect. Most journalists and television anchors now combine the role of presenter, prosecutor and judge in the service of their masters' preferred agendas. That the pillars of Indian democracy have frayed over the years is an inescapable conclusion tested on the touchstone of practised politics and constitutional philosophy.

The worrying indifference of the citizenry

But the failure of India's politics to promote substantive democracy does not rest with any one party, leader or an institution. The indifference of a vast section of the citizenry to the brazen aberrations of constitutional governance has contributed to a gradual hollowing out of an otherwise promising democracy, rendered hostage to visceral animosities and ideological bankruptcy. Hannah Arendt, the philosopher, reminded us of the “banality of evil”, implying the necessity of an enlightened citizenry to participate in the life of the nation in a dialectical relationship between politics and society. Amartya Sen's idea of democracy premised on “participatory living and government by discussion” eludes us. Indeed, the popular response against routinised state violence and atrocities against the weak has not been loud enough to invite the necessary structural changes in the processes of

Financial democracy, the Jan Dhan transformation

Does ideology matter in governance? Yes, it does. A case in point is the Jan Dhan Yojana, which marks 12 years this Independence Day and has served the cause of Antyodaya, a concept propounded by both Mahatma Gandhi and Deendayal Upadhyaya. Simply put, it means that the most deprived should be considered the most deserving when it comes to the distribution of the fruits of development.

Independence Day is usually understood in political terms. India became a sovereign republic, established democratic institutions and introduced universal suffrage. But political independence alone does not guarantee economic liberty. For millions of Indians, even decades after 1947, the formal financial system remained distant. A bank account, formal credit, insurance or a reliable channel to receive government support could not be taken for granted. Add to this the menace of pilferage, and the systemic failure is complete. No wonder a former Prime Minister had to admit that when a rupee was sent from Delhi, only 15 paise reached the recipient.

The vision

On August 15, 2014, from the ramparts of the Red Fort, the newly elected Prime Minister, Narendra Modi, made financial inclusion part of his Independence Day address.

Among several major announcements made during the address, he announced the Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana (PMJDY). The idea sounded simple: every household in India should have access to a bank account, a RuPay debit card and insurance cover. At Vigyan Bhawan on August 28, during the launch of the PMJDY implementation, Mr. Modi quoted Chanakya: *Sukhasya moolam dharmah* – the root of happiness is *dharmah*; *Dharmasya moolam artha* – the root of *dharmah* is *artha*; and *Arthasya*



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Twelve years of Jan Dhan have led to financial inclusion and independence

moolam rajyam – the root of *artha* is the state. The argument was that economic means are fundamental to human well-being and, therefore, creating access to those means is also a responsibility of the state.

The bank account was not simply another government benefit; rather, it was an entry point into the formal economy. The PMJDY, therefore, deserves to be viewed through the lens of Independence Day and the Prime Minister's thought leadership. India's first independence was about freeing the country from colonial rule. The second challenge was to build a state in which freedom could actually be exercised by ordinary citizens. If a citizen cannot access formal finance, receive money directly, save securely or establish a connection with the institutions through which economic opportunity flows, political freedom remains incomplete in a very practical sense.

The PMJDY attempted to address one part of that gap.

The numbers tell a story

The architecture also reflected the idea of *Antyodaya*: the last person in the queue should not remain outside the system. A zero-balance account meant that having little money was no longer, in principle, a reason to remain outside the banking system. A RuPay card and an overdraft facility were intended to make the account something that could actually be used.

Financial inclusion is not merely about opening accounts; it is about becoming part of a system of savings, payments, credit, insurance and economic opportunity. Twelve years later, the scale of that first step is difficult to ignore. By July 2026, the PMJDY had crossed 58 crore accounts, with deposits running into ₹3 lakh crore. More than half of the accounts are held by women, while roughly three-fourths are in rural and semi-urban areas.

governance. It is trite, therefore, that “the ballot box echos the living room”, leaving us Indians with the shell without the substance of democracy.

Because politics mirrors the state of society, and its values and failings, the task of national renewal must begin by looking inwards to apply the correctives. A social and political order that allows the brutalisation of a person in custody without meaningful recourse, which contents itself with illusory and wholly inadequate welfare schemes for crores of indigent persons and is not outraged enough at the unspeakable atrocities against children, youth, women and the marginalised, invites a decisive self indictment. We know that “when society rewards greed, politics becomes transactional. When it condones deception and lies, leaders tend to follow”.

Ennobling politics is not about manipulative conversations in which patriotism and truth are perceived as mutually exclusive. Politics that insists on a history made to order, negates the historical continuum and carries within the seeds of its rejection. Responsive democracy can thrive only in an inclusive society guided by a moral compass transcending the seductions of realpolitik. Elevating politics suffused with purpose presupposes a social milieu in which conscience prevails over power and where idealism is not dismissed as a utopian impossibility. The obvious needs reiteration, lest it is forgotten.

The choice before Indians

It is, therefore, for We, The People, to ensure that a larger political morality rooted in ethical fundamentals prevails over narrow identities in a renaissance of political culture that defers to justice, social, economic and political, as the ultimate command of the Constitution. Wisened by history and empowered by reason, it is for Indians, as inheritors of a free nation, to ensure that a democracy envisioned to enrich lives does not waste itself through acquiescence in injustice of any kind.

The debt of gratitude owed to India's freedom fighters summons Indians at this transformative moment to make choices that will place them on the right side of history – on the side of freedom and justice for all.

In conclusion, this writer repeats what he had written when India turned 75. “It is time to conquer our fears, reclaim our freedom and anchor our politics in honour that values principle over power”. And as Frantz Fanon had reminded us, it is for each generation to “discover its mission, fulfil or betray it”. The outcome of the recent students' protest at Jantar Mantar carries a hopeful message that democracy and dignity, despite the challenges, are secure in the idealism of the youth, inspired by a purifying sense of justice.

The views expressed are personal

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

A place for the heroes

As we celebrate India's 80th Independence Day, a deep sense of regret weighs heavily upon us: India still does not have a comprehensive and integrated national museum where the complete history of its great freedom movement, the sacrifices of countless

known and unknown freedom fighters, and the long and arduous journey towards Independence can be preserved and presented in one place. The leaders of post-Independence India devoted themselves to the monumental task of bringing together a nation of extraordinary diversity in languages, cultures,

religions, communities and traditions, and building a modern, democratic and sovereign state. For many among the younger generation, the lives and sacrifices of countless freedom fighters, revolutionaries, social reformers and nation-builders are becoming increasingly

unfamiliar. Their contributions cannot be adequately preserved merely through a few chapters in textbooks or ceremonial remembrance on national occasions. If we cannot properly preserve the memory of the struggle and sacrifices of those who gave their lives for our freedom, then what is the

deeper meaning of celebrating Independence Day?

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The politics of language

The politicisation of English is deeply regrettable. Promoting Indian languages need not come at the expense of English; the two

can develop simultaneously. India's linguistic diversity has historically demonstrated its capacity to accommodate multiple languages and cultural influences.

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